



SHETLAND ISLANDERS

A VIKING FIRE FESTIVAL RECALLS A SCANDINAVIAN INVASION

ON THE LAST TUESDAY OF JANUARY, nearly 1,000 men in Lerwick, the capital of the Shetland Islands, march in a torchlight procession behind a Viking longship carried through the streets. A relatively modern festival, *Up-Helly-Aa* only came into being in 1870 when a group of local men dreamed up the name and injected Viking disguises and a formal procession into a local post-Christmas celebration. They are led by an elected leader, *Guizer Jarl*, and his squad of Vikings. Following him, go 40 separate squads, each with its own theme and matching costume. The march ends with the spectacular blaze as the longship is set alight, but the revelry goes on all night with every squad visiting each of the 11 local halls in turn to perform funny sketches for the benefit of the townspeople.

